

CASE STUDY

Cyberbullying is a form of online harassment where individuals use digital platforms—such as social media, messaging apps, or forums—to repeatedly harm, threaten, or humiliate others. It differs from traditional bullying because it can occur continuously and reach a wide audience instantly. (Megan Meier Foundation)

A well-known real case is that of Megan Meier (2006) in the United States. Megan, a 13-year-old girl, was contacted on MySpace by a boy named “Josh Evans.” Initially, he befriended her, gaining her trust. This reflects the first step of cyberbullying: identifying and engaging the target. Next, the interaction escalated —“Josh” began sending cruel and hurtful messages, including statements that the world would be better without her. This demonstrates the second stage: emotional manipulation and harassment. Finally, the abuse became public and overwhelming, leaving Megan feeling isolated and distressed. Tragically, she died by suicide shortly afterward. (CBS News)

Typically, victims are adolescents who are active online, especially those who may already feel socially vulnerable. Cyberbullies often exploit anonymity, making it easier to avoid accountability while intensifying harm. (Megan Meier Foundation)

The consequences are severe and long-lasting. Victims may experience anxiety, depression, low self-esteem, and academic decline. In extreme cases, like Megan’s, cyberbullying can contribute to self-harm or suicide. Additionally, perpetrators may face legal or social consequences. This case highlights the urgent need for awareness, parental supervision, and responsible online behavior.

Source: Megan Meier Foundation; CBS News report on Megan Meier case.